‘Must have been the commandant’s fault too,’ I added. ‘After all, he’s responsible for the well-being of the academy’s pupils. A careless commandant is the last thing this academy needs.’

‘The commandant has other things to look after too,’ she said in a tone that sounded defensive.

‘You sound as if you know the commandant,’ I commented as we finished covering the window.

‘Well,’ she took a pause, picked up a glass of water and said, ‘I think I do.’

‘Yes, and I think I know the president of India,’ I said comically.

She smiled at me and said, ‘I’m the commandant’s daughter, Gunjan.’

I let out a laugh at first, but then I stared at Anuradha and knew she wasn’t lying.

‘I’m Anuradha Nair, Air Marshal K.N. Nair’s daughter,’ she said plainly. ‘But please don’t tell anyone.’

‘Oh, I’m sorry if I said anything bad,’ I said.

‘It’s okay,’ she said.

Being the commandant’s daughter must have had its own privileges, I thought at first. But Anuradha was just another cadet and liked being treated as one, I would realize later. For instance, the mess secretary had offered Anuradha curtains on the first day, but she had refused, saying she would take them once they had been issued for all other cadets. Her parents lived inside the academy, and yet, they would never come to meet her until she would earn her liberty. This, and many other similar instances, spoke a lot about what kind of person she was, and that somehow drew me to her. We would become inseparable friends during the entire training and would remain friends long after it ended.

I tasked Anuradha with waking me up the next morning. I had never been a morning person, and for someone who could sleep through a bomb blast, I knew I’d miss out on every alarm. She did as I had asked; little did she know that she would have to carry out this duty for the next three terms. The central fall-in in the games rig outside the FCM was scheduled at quarter to six in the morning. A report was given to the instructor officer